

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter School Overview

Michigan — MERC / NLRB Region 7 Jurisdiction — May 2026

NAPCS Unionization Research • May 2026 • Template v8.0

Section 1: State Overview

State	Michigan
Labor Board	MERC / NLRB Region 7 — Michigan Employment Relations Commission (MERC) — primary for locally/ISD-authorized charters; National Labor Relations Board Region 7 (Detroit) — for independently incorporated nonprofits
Governing Law	SPLIT JURISDICTION: (1) MERC under PERA (Mich. Comp. Laws §423.201 et seq.) for locally-authorized and ISD-authorized charter schools (public employers); (2) NLRB Region 7 (Detroit, prefix "07-") for privately incorporated charter nonprofits under NLRA. Authorizer type is the determinative factor — same pattern as Illinois. Michigan calls charter schools "Public School Academies (PSAs)." Prop 22 (November 2022) repealed right-to-work for private-sector workers effective March 2023 / February 2024 (private sector NLRB workers); card-check (majority sign-up) available for MERC-jurisdiction schools under PERA.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB Region 7 (Detroit) applies to independently incorporated charter school nonprofits. MERC applies to locally/ISD-authorized charters (public employers). Many NAPCS MI schools are authorized by universities (CMU, GVSU, Bay Mills CC, Eastern Michigan, Oakland, Saginaw Valley, Lake Superior State, Macomb ISD, etc.) — authorizer analysis required for each school to determine jurisdiction. Arts Academy in the Woods (Macomb ISD-authorized) was organized via NLRB, suggesting NLRB asserts jurisdiction even for ISD-authorized schools in some cases.
Right-to-Work	Right-to-Work State — Mich. Comp. Laws §423.14 (enacted 2012, effective 2013; repealed February 2024 for private-sector NLRB-jurisdiction employers) (Michigan enacted right-to-work in 2012 (effective March 2013). Michigan voters passed Proposition 22 in November 2022 repealing right-to-work for private-sector workers; repeal took effect February 2024. NLRB-jurisdiction charter schools (privately incorporated) are now no longer subject to right-to-work — new CBAs may include union security clauses. MERC-jurisdiction charter schools (public employers) were never subject to right-to-work; PERA governs. RTW status: effectively NO for NLRB-jurisdiction charters as of February 2024; never applied to MERC-jurisdiction charters.)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	YES — Card-check (WMA — majority sign-up without election) available for MERC-jurisdiction (public employer) charter schools under PERA. Right-to-work repealed March 2023 (public sector) / February 2024 (private sector NLRA). NLRB-jurisdiction schools still require secret ballot election.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — May 8, 2026 (Registry v37 MERC/NLRB R7 scan) — 373 charter schools searched
Research Window	May 2026 (initial session)

Section 2: Charter School Landscape

Total charter schools in Michigan: 373 (Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 374 open MI charter schools as of May 2026). Registry v94 audit June 5, 2026: 373 Open. Prior count overcounted by 1. 6 Closed schools excluded per census methodology.). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
Total Organized Charter Schools in Michigan	10	2.7%	Active CONFIRMED NAPCS schools. AAW (C2601002), Cesar

			Chavez Academy network (4 campuses — Michigan ACTS/AFT, certified Feb 7, 2013), Grand Rapids Child Discovery Center (C2600004 — MERC, union name pending FOIA). UYA (C2610008) certified 2015 but CBA status unknown post-management-change — counted separately. Denominator: 374 open MI charter schools (Registry v50).
Independently Organized (CONFIRMED)	10	2.7%	AAW (C2601002) — Michigan ACTS/AFT Local 6482, ~Jan 2012, 20-1 vote. Cesar Chavez Academy HS/Intermediate/Middle/Elementary (C2601012, C2609001, C2699073, C2699074) — Michigan ACTS/AFT, certified Feb 7, 2013, second contract ratified 91-3 (~2016). GRCDC (C2600004) — unknown union, MERC, active CBA per 2025-26 transparency page.
Certified — CBA Status Disputed/Unknown	1	0.3%	UYA (C2610008) — Michigan ACTS/AFT Local 6482, NLRB case 07-RC-148928, May 14, 2015, 27-18 vote. CBA status unknown post-management-change (Leona Group departure; NPFE now manages). Requires NLRB ADS search to confirm current status.
Total Charter Schools in Michigan	374	100%	Source: Charter School Registry v50 (NCES/ELSI 2024-25; 374 open MI charter schools as of May 2026).

Charter School Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	154,171 students — 10.8% of state K–12 enrollment (1,423,933 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	60,400 students in network-affiliated schools — 39.2% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	4,164 students (2.7% of charter enrollment) — 2,745 in CMO/EMO-affiliated schools (1.8%); 1,419 in independently organized schools (0.9%)
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
National Heritage Academies	EMO	58	—	—	38,403
University Preparatory Schools (UPrep)	EMO	10	—	—	4,533
Pontiac Academy for Excellence	EMO	2	—	—	553
GEE Educational	CMO	15	—	—	4,572
Cesar Chavez Academy	CMO	4	—	4	2,294
Chandler Park Academy	CMO	3	—	—	2,019
Detroit Academy of Arts and Sciences	CMO	3	—	—	1,033
Old Redford Academy	CMO	3	—	1	957
Summit Academy North	CMO	3	—	—	1,574
Advanced Technology Academy	CMO	2	—	—	1,207
Detroit Edison Public School Academy	CMO	2	—	—	1,320
Great Lakes Learning Academy	CMO	2	—	—	923
Hope of Detroit Academy	CMO	2	—	—	1,012
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in Michigan		109		5	60,400
of which organized (1.8% of charter enrollment)				5	2,745

Total enrollment shown is the combined enrollment of all CMO/EMO network schools in Michigan. Organized network schools: 5 organized — 2,745 students in organized network schools (1.8% of total charter enrollment).

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.

‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

3 EMO (for-profit), 10 CMO (nonprofit). Approximately 264 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Charter School Overview

Findings are based on research as of May 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework

SPLIT JURISDICTION: (1) MERC under PERA (Mich. Comp. Laws §423.201 et seq.) for locally-authorized and ISD-authorized charter schools (public employers); (2) NLRB Region 7 (Detroit, prefix "07-") for privately incorporated charter nonprofits under NLRA. Authorizer type is the determinative factor — same pattern as Illinois. Michigan calls charter schools "Public School Academies (PSAs)." Prop 22 (November 2022) repealed right-to-work for private-sector workers effective March 2023 / February 2024 (private sector NLRB workers); card-check (majority sign-up) available for MERC-jurisdiction schools under PERA. Michigan is a right-to-work state (Mich. Comp. Laws §423.14 (enacted 2012, effective 2013; repealed February 2024 for private-sector

NLRB-jurisdiction employers)). Charter schools in Michigan are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (MERC / NLRB Region 7). Card-check recognition is available under Card-check (WMA — majority sign-up without election) available for MERC-jurisdiction (public employer) charter schools under PERA. Right-to-work repealed March 2023 (public sector) / February 2024 (private sector NLRA). NLRB-jurisdiction schools still require secret ballot election..

2: Charter School Structure

Michigan operates 373 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 154,171 students. 13 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in Michigan, including 3 for-profit EMOs. The largest networks by campus count are National Heritage Academies (58 campuses in state), GEE Educational (15 campuses in state), University Preparatory Schools (UPrep) (10 campuses in state). Approximately 264 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Press Coverage

Teachers at Detroit's Largest Charter School Win Second Contract — AFT Michigan — September 2016. Union Teachers at Detroit's Largest Charter School Win Unprecedented Settlement — AFT Michigan — March 31, 2014. Arts Academy in the Woods charter school teachers vote to unionize (first charter school in MI to unionize) — HuffPost / Michigan media — ~January 2012. University Yes Academy teachers vote to form union — AFT Michigan / Detroit Metro Times — May 7, 2015. NLRB steps in to hold Detroit charter school accountable — alter-ego employer complaint — AFT Michigan / Detroit Metro Times — March 29, 2016. State's largest charter school organized by labor union (MEA, 2000) — Michigan Education Report / Mackinac Center — May 2000.

Sourced Coverage

- [Teachers at Detroit's Largest Charter School Win Second Contract](#) — AFT Michigan, September 2016
- [Union Teachers at Detroit's Largest Charter School Win Unprecedented Settlement](#) — AFT Michigan, March 31, 2014
- [Arts Academy in the Woods charter school teachers vote to unionize \(first charter school in MI to unionize\)](#) — HuffPost / Michigan media, ~January 2012
- [University Yes Academy teachers vote to form union](#) — AFT Michigan / Detroit Metro Times, May 7, 2015
- [NLRB steps in to hold Detroit charter school accountable — alter-ego employer complaint](#) — AFT Michigan / Detroit Metro Times, March 29, 2016
- [State's largest charter school organized by labor union \(MEA, 2000\)](#) — Michigan Education Report / Mackinac Center, May 2000

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

MERC / NLRB Region 7 public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Arts Academy in the Woods (C2601002)	Arts Academy in the Woods Federation of Teachers (Michigan ACTS / AFT Local 6482)	Active — successive CBAs since ~2012-13 Unknown. Gap: CBA period not publicly posted. Obtainable via AFT Michigan or school HR directly (no FOIA required).	artsacad.net/employment/ — confirms active union. Direct request to school or AFT Michigan for CBA text — no FOIA required.
University Yes Academy (C2610008)	Michigan Alliance of Charter Teachers and Staff (Michigan ACTS /	UNKNOWN — certified May 14, 2015 (07-RC-148928); post-management-change	NLRB ADS case 07-RC-148928 public page confirmed. Post-2016: search NLRB ADS for "University Yes Academy" / "New Paradigm for Education" — free public search, no

	AFT Local 6482)	status unconfirmed Unknown — NLRB/MERC records request required	FOIA needed.
Cesar Chavez Academy network — all 4 NAPCS campuses (C2601012, C2609001, C2699073, C2699074)	Michigan Alliance of Charter Teachers & Staff (Michigan ACTS) / AFT Michigan	Second 5-year contract ratified 91-3 (~2016 per AFT Michigan press release). Post-Leona Group (~2019) successor contract status unknown. Second contract: ~2016-2021. Successor contract unknown — direct contact with Michigan ACTS (AFT Michigan, Detroit) or NLRB R7 FOIA required.	AFT Michigan (aftmichigan.org) — Michigan ACTS division. Direct contact for current CBA status. NLRB ADS search for "Cesar Chavez Academy" post-2019 for any new case filings.
Grand Rapids Child Discovery Center (C2600004)	Unknown — MERC FOIA required (merc@michigan.gov)	ACTIVE — confirmed via school transparency page (2025-26): "Health benefits for teaching staff are directed by the current bargaining agreement." Unknown — MERC FOIA required	childdiscoverycenter.org/transparency-reporting (confirms active CBA). Union identity: email merc@michigan.gov or contact GRPS HR.